Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.

a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

The money that comes onto the food stamps cards runs out in just 10 to 12 days. After that, we have to use our bank cards to buy necessities. We can't spend too much, focusing mostly on purchasing food items. Three days ago, money came onto our food stamps card, but it won't last until the end of the month, for the rest of the month we are using our bank card, in these past two months, the food stamps funds have been reduced and don't last, we have been using our bank card.

b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

I had two jobs one at Amazon and one at Walmart, and because of this, my food stamps were cut off for two months, the food stamp for discontinued then I called DWS to inquire why my food stamps hadn't arrived, and they told me it was because my income was too high. My second job was at Amazon which was seasonal I decided to resign, and I submitted my resignation. I told the DWS I resigned then they told me. Me to fill out Form 630, which I did and took to DWS. They said they would update my information, and at the end of August, my food stamps were reactivated, but the amount was reduced.

c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

When we arrived in Utah from the very first month we joined the CCS program, our case manager, who is a very kind person, applied for the food stamps on our behalf. They contacted the interview over the phone they provided interpretation. Within a week, they gave us the food stamps.

d. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

CCS is a process designed for immigrants who arrive, and it begins with food stamps and health training. The program aims to help enroll children in school. They assisted with this, but they did not apply for a job for me. They found a place for me to work which I declined because I had not been able to sort out my important contacts. They did not search for a job for me.

e. Can you tell me when food became a problem?

We completed the CCS after six months they supported us by paying the rent and providing bus cards. One critical resource is the food stamps, as it would be impossible to manage without them. In the past two months,

when the food stamps were cut off it created a lot of problems, especially since I lost my job as well. After I submitted my resignation, it took about a month and a half for the food stamps to be reactivated. During that time, we had to use between $700 to $900 from our bank account, which was very difficult. Once the food stamps were reactivated. The amount was reduced, and it was not enough to last the entire month it would only cover expenses for about 15 to 20 days after which we have to use our bank card again

You indicated that you have used the WIC program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

We were not familiar with this program. When we were with CCS, our case manager informed us about this program called WIC. They told us that a card would be issued to us and money would be loaded onto it each month I did not apply for it myself; our case manager handled everything for us.

Can you explain your experience with using this program?

The case manager scheduled the appointment, and I said they didn't need to come the clinic is so close just two minutes by car I would go by myself, when we went to the clinic we saw so many people and everything was provided for us.

Tell me about the food you received from them.

We are receiving, beans, milk, yogurt chicken, and $ 26 for vegetables and fruits.

What % of your foods come from this program?

10% is what is spent on a child; it is not too much more than that. It covers the necessary expenses for one child's needs. This is very good as it helps with nutrition and supports growth and development.

You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months. Can you tell me why you have not used food assistance programs during these times?

Can you explain your experiences with applying for food programs since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

My experience is that applying is easy for me. I call them, provide all my information like the case number, or go to the office or through my case website.

2. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.

When we need to buy our food, especially meat, we pay particular attention to it being halal. We go to Afghan Markets where halal meat is available. For example, green tea, black tea, and items that are diffuses to find elsewhere, but they are available in these Afghan markets, we get them from there.

a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

100% of our culture is very important to us, and we try hard to not adopt other cultures, especially their food. We strive to obtain our cultural traditions as it is very important and a priority for us.

b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

We get our vegetables from Walmart we can find vegetables in any store. However, for meat green tea, and black, we purchase from the halal market.

c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?

They helped a lot when we were in CCS our case manager provided us with the address halal market. They told us that we could find our traditional foods there. They also suggested that if we wanted to shop monthly, we could go to Costco, as it would be more economical, we didn't know about it but they guided us.

What did they do that was the most helpful and why?

The food stamps are extremely helpful, we haven't received any other government benefits, and, normally, they provide housing rent assistance to everyone for up to six months, but the food stamps have been a significant help, and I truly felt absence during the past two months. When the food stamps were not available it was very challenging without them.

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview, and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

The negative aspect here in America is that it feels like they don't allow a person to stand on their own feet. Initially, I was working at Walmart, earning $15 an hour which amounted to around $2000 this income was used to pay for rent, car insurance, and bills, but it was not sufficient. I had to find another job for myself when I got the Job at Amazon both my Medicaid and food stamps were cut off which became a new challenge. Without Medicaid if we face any health shows we cannot cover the expenses with our income I was forced to resign from one of my Job what earnings from my current Job I can only cover rent bills car fuel and insurance living nothing extra their system makes it difficult for anyone to progresses they should consider the challenges faced by Afghan and how dire the situation is in Afghanistan there are no Jobs and many people are confined to their homes. They have hope in us, their family members aboard believing we have jobs and can support them however when I look at my situation here, I realize I can barely manage on my own and cannot support them as I wish

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

New immigrants in America often find themselves in unfamiliar territory lacking knowledge about various programs available to them, such as food assistance. Most of this information is provided through organizations like IRC and CCS, which serve as significant resources for guidance. They play a system and understand how to access the support they need.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

I am very happy that you have come to conduct interviews. It would be great if someone like you could visit each family to ask about their problems. This way, they can share their concern if they have any. If not, it reassures them that everything is fine, and they feel safe without the burden of psychological stress. Food insecurity is a significant difficulty, I am glad you came to our house and allowed me to express my problems. This situation highlights that while I may not face server issues, many others have many challenges.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

Since we arrived, we have encountered truly wonderful people. Our caseworker was incredibly supportive and worked with us in a brotherly and sincere manner. We didn't face many problems because they provided excellent guidance. So far, we have managed to resolve issues with CCS, but if we counter any difficulties, we know we can contact them, and they respond promptly. Their support has been invaluable. Initially, we lacked experience and faced challenges but were guided as to a better place. When we reflected on their situation and noticed the increasing requests from Afghanistan, I decided to take action. I thought that pursuing two jobs would be beneficial, and I took steps toward another position. This experience has shown me how challenging it can be without Medicaid and food stamps.